

Blast from the past: A section of spectators filled the giant stands to watch the finals of the 81st All India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup Hockey tournament in Chennai in 2003. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY



attendance.

One of the main reasons for this lack of interest is the increasingly crowded international calendar, which makes it nearly impossible for the core group of 30-35 national team players to participate.

"Around 30 players will always be occupied with international assignments—rest, recovery, and preparation for the next tournament. If they get a gap of one to one-and-a-half months, they can come and play. But for a break of just one week or 10-15 days, there's no point in coming and playing here," said Raghunath, who retired from international hockey in 2017 but continues to represent IOCL in the domestic circuit.

Another factor contributing to the decline in crowds, according to B.P. Govinda, a member of the 1975 World Cup-winning team, is the national team's inconsistent performance on the international stage over the past two decades.

DESPITE ITS GLORIOUS PAST, DOMESTIC TOURNAMENTS LIKE THE MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP HAVE WITNESSED A SIGNIFICANT DECLINE IN SPECTATOR TURNOUT

"When we played these tournaments, the whole stadium used to be full. Back then, the Indian team won many tournaments — like the bronze medal at the 1972 Munich Olympics, the silver at the 1973 World Cup, and the gold at the 1975 World Cup," he said.

"Since 1975, the Indian team hasn't been on the podium at the World Cup — it's been almost 50 years. After that [1975 World Cup], there hasn't been anything to draw in spectators," he opined.

"The public will return once the team starts winning international tournaments. The Indian team won

bronze medals at the Tokyo and Paris Olympics. If you keep winning, people will come to meet their heroes," he added.

Nasser, a fan who has been following the event for over a decade, suggests that the quality of the sport has dwindled compared to previous years. "Dribbling has gone down, and the schematic moves we used to see have decreased too. Now, it's all about aerial passes and penalty corners," he said.

"Earlier, we could identify players by their unique style of play. One player who immediately comes to mind is Dhanraj Pillay — he was the